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Vernacular Classicism and the Mausoleum of Halicarnassus: The Architectural Imaginary of a Danish Interwar Crematorium

Abstract

This article discusses a crematorium inaugurated in 1923 in the municipal Northern Cemetery (*Nordre Kirkegård*) of Aarhus, Denmark, as a case of vernacular classicism in interwar Denmark. While earlier works by its architect Sophus Frederik Kühnel (1851-1930) followed National Romantic, Renaissance and Gothic models, the crematorium stands out because of its crowning feature, a stepped pyramid roof that emulates one of the most characteristic architectural elements of the mid-fourth-century BCE Mausoleum of Halicarnassus, described by Pliny (*HN* 36.31) and other ancient authors. This reference to one of the most famous funerary monuments from classical antiquity is both functionally and symbolically appropriate in a cemetery setting and also fits into a longer history of "Mausoleumania", both in Denmark and internationally. It furthermore reflects a broader architectural movement of vernacular, "Nordic" classicism during the interwar period where local architects "translated" classical elements into the vernacular, for example, through prominent use of brickwork and eclectic combinations of classical motifs with both medieval and national romantic forms. Kühnel's crematorium shows some of the creative ways in which Scandinavian architects freely adapted distinctive elements from the repertoire of classical architecture, in this case in response to the rise of cremation.

Introduction

The role of classical heritage in European cityscapes is typically studied through landmark architecture and art in capital cities, as well as the singular artists who conceived them.[1] This is certainly true in the study of Danish classicism where extensive scholarship has been devoted to canonical artists, such as the sculptors Johannes Wiedewelt (1731-1802) and Bertel Thorvaldsen (1770-1844), the Hansen architect brothers Christian (1803-83) and Theophil (1813-91), and their role in the conception of neo-classical monuments in Copenhagen (and abroad).[2] Much less attention has been given to the more architecturally

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[1] See, for example, Temple, Piotrowski and Heredia (2019).

[2] For overviews of Danish classicism, see Jensen (2007), Horster and Funder (2017) and Funder, Kristensen and Nørskov (2019). Other general studies of the classicism of Danish artists and travellers include Nielsen (1990), Haugsted (1996), Christiansen (2000), and Fejfer, Rathje and Fischer-Hansen (2003).

ambiguous buildings and artworks from the late 19th century onwards that translated classical models into looser, more eclectic and admittedly less idealised forms.[3]

This article looks at one example of vernacular classicism during the interwar period in Aarhus, Denmark's second largest city. Vernacular classicism has occasionally been defined as non-elite reception of the classics, but I here follow the literary scholar Matthew Day's use of the term to describe how fifteenth-century translators and authors, such as William Caxton, worked freely with both classical texts and a rich repertoire of vernacular traditions, for example, courtly romances and medieval adaptations of Greek and Roman originals.[4] In a similar fashion, this article will discuss how references to one specific monument from the corpus of classical architecture appear in a late work by the Danish architect Sophus Frederik Kühnel (1851-1930). Kühnel's earlier works are closely aligned with the historicism that had dominated Danish architecture since the 1890s. However, in the design of a crematorium inaugurated in 1923 in a cemetery in the hilly northern outskirts of Aarhus, prominent classical references appear (Fig. 1). The crematorium is topped by a stepped pyramid roof and adorned with sculptural decoration on all four sides inspired by the mid-fourth-century BCE Mausoleum of Halicarnassus (modern Bodrum, Türkiye), one of the seven wonders of the ancient world with a long history of reception stretching back to antiquity itself. I argue that this adaptation of a late classical funerary monument not only appealed to Kühnel's practical sensibilities but also resonates with a broader architectural movement of vernacular classicism during the interwar period. What inspired Kühnel to draw on this specific, classical model for the design of his crematorium? And what do these choices tell us about the shifting meanings of classicising architecture in the context of a northern European "second city"?[5] Before turning to these questions in more detail, we need to begin with some examples of how classicism has shaped the cityscape of Aarhus and how they reflect the city's history and self-representation.

Classicism and its Discontents in a Northern European "Second City"

Aarhus was founded as a Viking age settlement and harbour on the eastern coast of Jutland in the late eighth century CE. From the 19th century it experienced considerable growth and

[3] However, on interwar classicism, see Silver (2010).
[4] Day (2022).
[5] On the comparable classical cityscape of Gothenburg, another Scandinavian "second city", see Lovén and Synnestvedt (2021).

expanded beyond its medieval walls. Towards the end of the century, it gradually overtook rival towns to become the main city of the Jutland peninsula, not least due to substantial infrastructural investments.[6] It was over the course of the 19th century and the first half of the following century that classicism made its strongest impact on Aarhus's cityscape through classicising elements and features in local architecture.[7] The first wave of "Golden Age" classicism from *c*. 1800 is seen in private residences, notably those of the merchants Harboe Meulengracht (1767-1853) on Lille Torv (1816) adorned with four Ionic capitals on its façade, and Hans Broge (1822-1908) in Mindegade 8 (1849).[8] Classical references also appeared in shop decoration, such as the Pompeian wall paintings and statues that adorn the courtyard of the "Svane" pharmacy (1876), operated by the Copenhagen-born pharmacist Adolph V.J. Meyer (1835-1909).[9] From the mid-19th century, the public monuments and institutions that the town increasingly attracted because of its growing affluence and national importance also drew on neoclassical archetypes, typically through the intervention of architects with formal education in the capital's Royal Danish Academy of Fine Arts (founded 1754), as evident from decoration of the interior rooms of the Jydske Asyl psychiatric hospital (1849-52) designed by Michael Gottlieb Bindesbøll (1800-56).[10]

The city expanded most rapidly during the latter part of the 19th century. When classical motifs and themes were used in this period, they were juxtaposed with elements taken from other periods and places, drawing on the paradigm of historicism that favoured "a synthesis of all past styles that could form the true expression of the present."[11] Some commentators have disapprovingly labelled historicism as "exuberant carnival architecture",[12] but its monuments may be seen as palimpsests of Danish national identity and as expressing the country's imagined geography that stretched from Viking Age Scandinavia to Renaissance Italy and, to a more limited extent, ancient Greece and Rome as well.[13] Historicism also reflected a society that was changing, both in terms of its new democratic politics (with the so-called system change in 1901, Denmark had obtained its first liberal government based on

[6] Beck (1997); Johansen (1997; 1998); Fink (1998).
[7] The classical heritage of the Aarhus cityscape has only recently received attention in Danish-language publications that place the evidence within a predominantly local framework, see papers in Nørskov (2008a) on architecture, Hannestad (2008) on sculpture, as well as Kristensen and Nørskov (2018).
[8] Nørskov (2008b); Beck (1997: 47-52); Langkilde (1986: 141-147).
[9] Sejr (1960: 28).
[10] On *Jydske Asyl*, see Nørskov (2008c).
[11] Hvattum (2009: 151).
[12] My translation from Beck (1997: 51, "frodig karnevalsarkitektur").
[13] On this imagined geography and its conflicting identities, see Funder, Kristensen and Nørskov (2020: 7-16).

a parliamentary majority) and the impact of industrialisation and the new commercial and creative opportunities that it brought about.[14] At the same time, the architectural movement of National Romanticism favoured early medieval motifs and national craft traditions for the design of buildings.[15] It was within this complex tapestry of aesthetic paradigms and social and political transformation that new kinds of vernacular classicism emerged.

The waxing-and-waning of the period's relationship with classical architecture is clear from the career of Hack Kampmann (1856-1920). Kampmann was a prominent proponent of Danish historicism and National Romanticism, not least in Aarhus whose cityscape he profoundly shaped during tenure as Royal Inspector of Buildings in Northern Jutland from 1892 to 1908.[16] His works in Aarhus employed a rich and playful tapestry of styles, including an affinity for organic and fantastical motifs associated with the National Romantic *Skønvirke* movement (1880-1910).[17] During his student years at the Royal Academy, Kampmann excelled in drawing classical ruins, but following a later visit to the Athenian Acropolis, he remarked that both classical architecture and the modern monuments that it inspired was "born under the bright days and warm sun of the south, and it will never become a real truth (*en rigtig Sandhed*) among us" due to the dissimilarity between the Danish and the Mediterranean climates.[18] His Customs House in Aarhus (1895-7) is thus in an entirely National Romantic style, with rich use of red brick fully engaged in the historicist sublimation of brick architecture.[19] However, in many later works, Kampmann returned to classical motifs. In Aarhus Theatre (1900), while continuing the predilection for red brick, he opted for a pediment in the style of a Doric temple to celebrate the Greek origins of drama (Fig. 2).[20] The pediment was in turn decorated with a scene from Ludvig Holberg's *Masquerade* (1724), giving a classicising frame to the celebration of Denmark's most important playwright. The two arched entryways below add a distinctively "local" feel to this

[14] Nørskov (2008d); Dybdahl (1978: 433-502).
[15] Particularly evident in the clash between historicist and neoclassical architects before the construction of Martin Nyrop's neo-medieval Copenhagen City Hall (1892-1905), see Lane (2000), 180-189.
[16] Kampmann's prominence is apparent from recent literature that includes a two-volume biography (Gehl and Soldbro (2015); Dirckinck-Holmfeld, Gehl and Soldbro (2015), as well as the fact that a major urban space was named after him in 2009. On his works, see also Stewart (2018: 77-92) and Thule Kristensen (2023).
[17] On *Skønvirke*, a Danish parallel to the Art and Crafts Movement, see Gelfer-Jørgensen (2004; 2020).
[18] Cited from Nørskov (2008e: 86, my translation). Such views rested on an aesthetic philosophy that argued that contemporary art should rest on a "re-birth" of Nordic history and that goes back to at least the 1840s in Denmark, see Thule Kristensen (2023: 197-201).
[19] Nyrop's Copenhagen Town Hall took this tradition of artisanal and local pride to further heights.
[20] Nørskov (2008e); Stewart (2018: 80-81). The mosaic decoration of the pediment was designed by Karl Hansen Reistrup (1863-1929).

new flourishing of classical elements and mark a formal connection back to the nearby Customs House. Several of Kampmann's subsequent works made further strives in leaving behind historicist and National Romantic ideals and generating new engagements with classicism.[21] Architectural historians have indeed described these later works as part of a "Nordic Classicism", when many Nordic architects between 1910 and 1930 increasingly rejected National Romanticism and returned to classical role models for inspiration while combining them with the starker and more minimal visual language of early modernism.[22]

Further testimony to the changing dynamics of classicism are found in Aarhus's National Exhibition (*Landsudstillingen*), held from 15 May to 15 September 1909 and marking a turning point in announcing the city's newly acquired status as an industrial and culturally ambitious centre worthy of the title of "capital of Jutland" (Fig. 3). The city's emboldened sense of self-importance was manifested through the exhibition's programmatic use of specific classical models, but these were once again freely adapted into the local vernacular through the dominant use of elaborate wood constructions, designed by Anton Rosen (1859-1928).[23] Prominent classicising elements at the exhibition included a large "Hall of Industry" with the appearance of a Greek temple, a monumental triumphal arch (promoting Carlsberg beer) and an honorific column (promoting Tuborg beer) in the style of that of Trajan in Rome. An official poster advertising the exhibition enshrined the ideal of the classical yet modern city through depiction of a horse-shoe shaped ornament topped by two triglyphs set between the city seal and Roman-looking garlands (Fig. 4). There were several other allusions in the 1909 National Exhibition to classical antiquity (one of which we will return to later) as well as to national archaeology and history, such as a Neolithic dolmen.[24] As such, it drew inspiration from a range of different pasts to provide solid foundations for the future, including answers to the question of what Aarhus as the modern second-city of Denmark should look like in the age of industrialisation and rapid technological progress. When a new train station was inaugurated in 1927, yet another answer to that question came through the erection of a monumental edifice that borrowed distinctive architectural forms from the Temple of Apollo at Didyma, uncovered by German archaeologists just a couple of

[21] Examples include the Ny Carlsberg Glyptotek discussed later, the Copenhagen Police Headquarters (1918-24), Viborg Katedralskole (1922) and Randers Statsskole (1918-26).
[22] Paavilainen (1982); Stewart (2018); Charrington (2019). Influential proponents of this movement include the Swedish architects Ivar Tengbom (1878-1968), Gunnar Asplund (1885-1940) and Sigurd Lewerentz (1885-1975).
[23] Christiansen (2023).
[24] Bender (2008).

decades earlier, but predominantly and proudly constructed with yellow bricks (Fig. 5).[25] Through its translation of architectural forms from new archaeological discoveries and Mediterranean marble into a brick façade, the train station may be taken as another representative of vernacular classicism.

Kühnel's Crematorium and its Classical Imaginary

Kühnel's crematorium belongs to this story of an emerging vernacular classicism in the interwar period (Figs. 1 and 6). It was constructed in Aarhus's municipal Northern Cemetery (*Nordre Kirkegård*) that had been inaugurated in 1876 as a supplement to the older cemetery south of the city (*Søndre Kirkegård*, established 1818).[26] The cemetery quickly expanded, and in 1898 it was incorporated into a new urban masterplan.[27] Plans for the addition of a crematorium were developed in the late 1910s in response to ongoing debates about the hygienic and economic virtues of cremation in Denmark and abroad.[28] While cremation had become legal in 1892, only 1.4% of all deceased Danes were cremated in 1920.[29] The legal obligation to provide cremation services had by then passed from private societies, primarily the Danish Cremation Society (founded 1881), to local municipalities.[30] The first public crematorium in Denmark was built in Copenhagen's Bispebjerg cemetery in 1906-7 after designs by Holger Jacobsen (1876-1960).[31] Despite continued objections from several members of the cemetery's board, construction of the Aarhus crematorium began in 1918 in a time of widespread unemployment and bleak economic prospects. A newspaper report from that year accordingly complained that the cost of the crematorium had exceeded its substantial budget of DKK 50.000, while failing to create enough jobs.[32]

On 9 January 1923 the Northern Cemetery crematorium opened as the only second such public facility in Denmark with a trial cremation of a young heifer.[33] The crematorium was

[25] Pedersen (2008).
[26] Aarhus grew from 33.000 inhabitants in 1890 to 74.000 in 1921, see Fink (1998: 28).
[27] *Danmarks Kirker*, 16:3, 1321-1322.
[28] The earliest drawings of the crematorium were submitted to the municipality on 10 September 1918, according to the archives of Aarhus Municipality (Byggesagsarkivet, entry for Kirkegårdsvej 26).
[29] *Betænkning vedrørende revision af begravelsesloven og ligbrændingsloven angivet af det af Kirkeministeriet den 2. maj 1968 nedsatte udvalg*, p. 14.
[30] On the introduction of cremation and changes in 20th-century Danish burial practices (typically referred to in contemporary sources as *Ligbrændingssagen*), see Sommer (2006) and Sørensen (2009).
[31] Svane (1928: 38-40).
[32] *Aarhuus Stifts-Tidende* 3 February 1918, p. 3 ("De Arbejder, Aarhus sætter i Gang for at bøde for Arbejdsløsheden"). At its completion, the crematorium had cost a total of DKK 90.000, see Svane (1928: 37).
[33] *Aarhuus Stifts-Tidende* 9 January 1923, p. 1 ("Aarhus-Krematoriet indvies i Dag"); *Horsens Folkeblad,* 9 January 1923, p. 1 ("Det jyske Krematorium").

given a prominent position on the tree-lined, east-west axis (Fig. 7). Somewhat unusually the entrances to the crematorium did not face this main axis of the cemetery but were instead from the south and the north. As such they did not face the cemetery's chapel, constructed in 1880 in neo-Romanesque style. However, the crematorium was certainly visually imposing and stood at a height of *c.* 15m in elevated terrain overlooking the city's harbour. This meant that all travellers arriving in Aarhus from the sea would see the smoke rising from the chimney on top of the Mausoleum-inspired stepped pyramid roof.[34] Further to the northwest, the crematorium became a prominent part of the newly urbanised neighbourhood of Trøjborg that had Hack Kampmann's Church of St. John (1902-5) and its imposing tower as visual and social nexus.[35]

To understand the significance of the crematorium and its place within vernacular classicism, we need to look closer at the imaginary of its architect. Kühnel was a locally-based architect who previously had been responsible for minor adjustments to the Northern Cemetery's chapel.[36] Originally from Sæby in northern Jutland, at the age of two Kühnel had followed his vicar father to southern Schleswig, a region of Denmark that shortly after was lost to Prussia in the war of 1864. This childhood experience left him with a strong sense of national sentiment.[37] From 1871 to 1878, he attended the Royal Danish Academy of Fine Arts, receiving instruction from several prominent professors, including Christian Hansen, as well as Ferdinand Meldahl (1827-1908). Professors at the Academy at this time were split between between a cosmopolitan "Europeanism" (with some classical elements, often transmitted through Renaissance models) and a "historical-national" or vernacular perspective (with much more emphasis on features inspired by the Danish past).[38] While Hansen was known for his neoclassical works, including the main building of Athens University (1841), and a representative of the classicism of the Danish "Golden Age", Meldahl wanted Copenhagen to rival the Paris of Georges-Eugène Haussmann.[39] He freely applied influences from a wide spectrum of architectural epochs and international styles in his works, while emphasising the

[34] Making similar use of the landscape setting, a small lighthouse was installed in the Northern Cemetery during the 1927 expansion of the city's harbour (Byggesagsarkiv, Byggesag 519-27, last accessed 30 August 2023).
[35] As we see later, another of Kampmann's works may have inspired the design of the crematorium.
[36] Obituary in *Aarhuus Stifts-Tidende*, 14 October 1930.
[37] *Aarhuus Stifts-Tidende*, 10 May 1951, p. 3 ("Arkitekten, der bistod Den gamle Bys Skaber"). Kühnel was involved in the restoration of several churches and vicarages across Jutland. His inclination towards national history is furthermore clear from his involvement with Aarhus' *Den Gamle By* Museum. Founded 1914, this open-air museum is home to historic buildings from throughout Denmark.
[38] Madsen (1983: 141-2).
[39] Madsen (1983).

importance of the vernacular that he defined as "our country's characteristic conditions of construction" and the distinctive architectural heritage of Scandinavia and Denmark.[40]

After a brief stint working in Copenhagen for another influential historicist architect, Vilhelm Jens Dahlerup (1836-1907), Kühnel moved to Aarhus in 1879 to work on the restoration of the city's medieval cathedral.[41] The architectural office that he founded in 1882 later designed several prominent buildings whose façades freely borrowed from the repertoires of medieval and Renaissance architecture.[42] Among his public works are the Municipal Fire Station in Ny Munkegade (1904) that features a miniature, crenelated tower, taking a cue from the 13th-century Tower of Arnolfo in Florence. This tower was not only a flight of fantasy, but also had a practical function, since it was used to store the fire brigade's water hoses, a correlation between form and function that is characteristic of much of the period's architecture and that may have influenced Kühnel's design of the crematorium. On a number of occasions he went abroad on study trips to Germany and northern Italy. He never ventured to Greece that was quite clearly at the very periphery of his architectural imaginary.

Kühnel's crematorium in the Northern Cemetery was made of mainly red brick, in line with his earlier works that opted for this material with a long Danish pedigree.[43] But in designing the crematorium, he faced a new challenge of combining oven, furnace and chimney into an elegant design that met the requirements for this new type of building. Many other early crematoria had already turned to historic sacred buildings for inspiration. Peter Behrens's 1908 crematorium in Hagen (Germany) was thus based on an eleventh-century Florentine church.[44] The question of how to integrate a smoking chimney – already then an industrial icon – into the design of a cemetery was one of the most delicate tasks that faced contemporary architects when constructing crematoria.[45] At Bispebjerg, Holger Jacobsen had opted for a dome structure that, similar to Kühnel's later design, also embedded the chimney

[40] Meldahl cited in Madsen (1983: 142, my translation). Kühnel's loyalties leaned mostly towards the latter, judging both on this basis of his own later works and the fact that he worked under the supervision of Meldahl in the interior decoration of Frederiksborg Castle.
[41] https://www.kulturarv.dk/kid/VisWeilbach.do?kunstnerId=8107&wsektion=alle (accessed 24 August 2023).
[42] These include a major bank on Lille Torv (1899), the interior of which was modelled on the 15th-century Palazzo Rucellai in Florence, and residential complexes (Elkjær 1977: 36-37). The most well-known example is Mejlborg (1896-98 and then rebuilt following a fire in 1899) that combines Renaissance and Gothic elements in its design. In an authoritative volume of civic history, Kühnel is noted for his private buildings and as "the architect of the bourgeoisie" (Fink 1998: 48).
[43] Stewart (2018: 6).
[44] Rampley (2021: 353-354).
[45] Svane (1928: 38).

within its core (Fig. 8). But this appears to a uniquely Danish experiment. For example, in the case of Hagen, it was the off-axis campanile that housed the chimney. As we saw, a crematorium was a new addition to the landscapes of Danish cemeteries, and there was a considerable degree of freedom and room for experimentation among contemporary architects who in many ways had to start from scratch when designing both the practical and the emotional spaces associated with this type of building.[46]

Kühnel's approach to these challenges was to place a coke-fired oven within a square tower-like structure that on the northern and southern sides were flanked by two smaller turret-like towers, both crowned with crosses. The south wing of the crematorium housed the furnace, whereas the north wing housed a small, crowded chapel where the coffin was placed on a catafalque (Fig. 9).[47] Whereas the small towers are evocative of Medieval castle architecture, a reference that Kühnel also made in several other buildings, he chose a very specific classical reference by crowning the large tower with the stepped pyramid construction in emulation of the Mausoleum of Halicarnassus (Fig. 10). The pediments on the four sides of the main tower were set within arched openings immediately below the stepped pyramid roof and strengthened the conceptual link to the Mausoleum. The openings were decorated with stone reliefs by the prolific local sculptor Elias Ølsgaard (1873-1964) and depicted Biblical scenes: nativity, Jesus healing a blind man, Crucifixion, and resurrection, motifs that were all appropriate for the eschatological aspirations of the crematorium. The sculptural adornment of the four sides of the tower emulated the design of the Mausoleum whose four sides were decorated with works by the some of the most famous artists of the fourth century BCE: Bryaxis, Timotheos, Leochares and Scopas.[48] Even if the scenes were Biblical in content, their overall conception was based on the Mausoleum model.

A number of other elements of the crematorium's design also have classical origins but are less distinctive. For example, on each side of the tower, the crematorium was decorated with wreaths in relief, drawing on an iconography of commemoration with roots going back to classical Greece.[49] Above these were placed four fire-emitting orbs (Fig. 6). The orbs may

[46] Cf. Parsons (2005) and Grainger (2020) on the English and Scottish cases.
[47] Some details of the interior design of the crematorium is unclear, as there are discrepancies between Kühnel's drawings (all from 1918). Some plans depict a basement level (as also clear from the presence of a staircase in Fig. 8) but it is not clear that this was ever constructed. To my knowledge, no interior photos of the final design exist.
[48] Plin. *HN* 36.30-31; Vitr. 7. pref. 12-13; 2.8.10-14.
[49] Jeffreys (2022: 250-251).

have been chosen as emblems of knowledge and authority, again with classical forebearers, such as an attribute of Zeus's divine powers, as famously seen in Phidias's Olympian Zeus, another wonder of the ancient world (Paus. 5.2.1-2). The fire certainly articulated the building's role as a place of cremation, while the orbs pointed to a particular kind of cosmic symbolism with a strong legacy in the classical world.[50]

Crematorium and Mausoleum

Both within Kühnel's oeuvre and contemporary funerary architecture, the Aarhus crematorium is unique in taking such direct inspiration from the Mausoleum of Halicarnassus. Later Danish crematoria emulated classical forms, such as Søndermarken on Frederiksberg (1928) designed by Frits Schlegel and Edvard Thomsen drawing inspiration from Roman *columbaria*, but Kühnel broke new ground with his evocation of the Mausoleum. To understand his motivations for opting for this particular classical model for his crematorium, we need to turn to the rich reception history of the Mausoleum, built in the mid-fourth century BC for the burial of the Carian satrap Mausolus and his sister-wife Artemisia II. Pliny famously described the roof of the Mausoleum as the *metae cacumen* or "truncated cone" (*NH* 36.31), even the specific design and appearance of this feature has been fiercely debated. Already in antiquity, the fame of the Mausoleum turned it into a model for emulation, predominantly in other funerary monuments, such as the Belevi Tomb outside Ephesus, constructed between 310 and 280/270 BCE.[51] However, after the 15th century when the stones of the original monument had been reused in Bodrum's crusader castle, the Mausoleum became an object of the imagination that could be freely appropriated. Indeed, from the Renaissance onwards there is an extensive tradition of reconstructing the Mausoleum and drawing inspiration from the design of its discrete elements, including the stepped pyramid roof.[52] Such reconstructions and appropriations relied on readings of the scattering of ancient sources that describe the monument in varying degrees of details, with Pliny as principal among them (*HN* 36.30-31).[53] An early example of this tradition is the "Sun Temple" depicted in a 1499 manuscript by Francesco Colonna that bears a striking similarity to Kühnel's designs (Fig. 11).[54]

[50] On this ancient tradition of symbolic architecture, see Thomas (2007: 53-69). Symbolic use of both circular and semi-circular designs is seen in Asplund and Lewerentz's "Skogskapell" (1918-20), see Stewart (2018: 160-166).
[51] Ruggendorfter (2016).
[52] Rodríguez-Moya and Mínguez (2017: 103-132).
[53] Jeppesen (1986).
[54] *Hypnerotomachia Poliphilii* (Venice 1499), b1 verso, and see Bury (1998).

Over time, the paper reconstructions of the Mausoleum came to inspire new buildings. A prominent first-mover was the English architect Christopher Wren (1632-1723) who in his 1673 designs for London's St Paul's Cathedral included a belfry with a stepped pyramidal roof based on the Mausoleum.[55] Although this feature ultimately was not built, the design is known both from architectural drawings and the so-called "Great Model". In 1730, Wren's pupil, Nicholas Hawksmoor, employed a similar design for the tower of St George's Church in Bloomsbury, whose façade in turn was modelled on the Pantheon in Rome. Over the course of the following centuries, "Mausoleumania" turned into a global craze, when the Mausoleum was appropriated in a range of buildings across the world, including sacred and commemorative monuments, such as the Masonic House of the Temple in Washington DC (1915), the Indiana World War Memorial in Indianapolis (1921) and the Shrine of Remembrance in Canberra (1934), many of which are much more immediately classicising than the Aarhus crematorium in their use of white stone and other classical elements (columns, pediments, *etc.*). By this point, the meagre archaeological remains of the Mausoleum had been located in excavations by Charles Newton in 1857.[56] The sculptures from the Mausoleum discovered by Newton were subsequently transported to the British Museum. It would later be a team of Danish classical archaeologists from Aarhus University that fully excavated other parts of the Mausoleum complex between 1966 and 1977.[57] The publications of this Danish fieldwork re-kindled a still ongoing debate about the reconstruction and height of the monument, as well as discussions about its complex place in cultural history, situated in a hybrid space between local (Karian), Greek, Anatolian and Persian practices.[58]

These scholarly discussions about the cultural origins of the architecture of the Maussolleion are curiously prefigured in newspaper reporting on Kühnel's crematorium for the occasion of its inauguration. Clearly in reference to its pyramidal roof, local newspapers noted that the crematorium was adorned with a "beautiful, oriental pagoda" (*smukke, østerlandsk*

[55] Hart (2020: 40-42).
[56] Jenkins (1992: 168-185); Funder, Kristensen and Nørskov (2019: 76-99).
[57] On the reconstruction of the Maussolleion superstructure, see Jeppesen (2002). The architecture of the Maussolleion was fiercely discussed in the archaeological literature of the early 20th century, notably in the publication of two seminal publications by the American architectural historian William Dinsmoor (1908a; 1908b).
[58] Jenkins (2010); on the politics of reconstructing the Maussolleion, see Kristensen, Nørskov and Bozoğlu (2021).

Pagode).[59] This reception that did not pick up on the Mausoleum reference may reflect specific descriptions of the monument in some of the speeches that were held at the inauguration. The fact that no one, including the architect himself, seemingly objected to them tells us something about both the attraction and the fluidity of the Mausoleum as a model. It was by definition a hybrid, combining motifs from the classical world (a specific funerary monument with considerable art historical and architectural pedigree in ancient Greece), Egypt (given that the pyramidal shape also referred to the much older Great Pyramid of Giza, another wonder of the ancient world) as well as something that in the early 20th century was simply seen as delightful exotica. Nor do any of the preserved technical descriptions of the Northern Cemetery crematorium make reference to the Mausoleum as the specific model for Kühnel's designs. Calculations of the statics of the building by the engineering firm Christiani and Nielsen simply describe it as the pyramidal spire (*det pyramidalske Spir*) and that it was made of reinforced concrete with stepped landings, showing how Kühnel did not abstain from using of modern construction materials.[60]

Kühnel did not himself explain his decision to draw inspiration from the Mausoleum. However, at least three motivations present themselves. The first relates to the specifically Danish reception history of the Mausoleum that gathered particular prominence after the turn of the 20th century. The most important example of this Danish tradition is Hack Kampmann's 1906 extension of the Ny Carlsberg Glyptotek that prominently incorporated a stepped roof pyramid in imitation of the Mausoleum, in this case made from granite and topped by a copy of the Athena Velletri (Fig. 12).[61] The Mausoleum reference reflects both the function of the building (that housed the Glyptotek's collection of classical antiquities) and Kampmann's return to classical forms. The Glyptotek's patron, the industrialist Carl Jacobsen (1842-1914), may have influenced the choice of the Mausoleum as a model for the expansion of the Glyptotek.[62] Indeed, it has been suggested that Jacobsen at some stage intended the space underneath the Glyptotek "Mausoleum" to serve as his burial place.[63] Kampmann had originally intended the façade's brickwork to be covered by marble plaster (in white or red), but ultimately decided against this, revealing an important aspect of

[59] The quote is from *Aarhuus Stifts-Tidende,* 9 January 1923, p. 2 ("Krematoriets Indvielse i Dag"); a similar wording, "østerlandsk Pagodestil", was reported in *Horsens Folkeblad,* 9 January 1923, p. 1 ("Det jyske Krematorium").
[60] *Statisk Beregning for Krematorium, Aarhus,* dated 30 September 1918 (Aarhus Municipality, Byggesagsarkiv, Sagsnr. 270-18, Dokument 19-08-2015, nr. 2, Statik).
[61] Stewart (2018: 81-82); Lægring (2023: 92-4); Søberg (2023: 143-153).
[62] Funder, Kristensen and Nørskov (2019: 76); Bender (2014: 482).
[63] For this suggestion, see Stubbe Østergaard (2011).

balancing out the classical and vernacular elements of his design.[64] In Aarhus, another evocation of the Mausoleum appeared at the 1909 National Exhibition. Here, an intriguingly pagoda-like, stepped roof pyramid crowns one of the gates that connected the different parts of the exhibition (visible in Fig. 3, just below the Carlsberg column). In this case, the Mausoleum reference was given an "orientalist" frame as it appeared alongside references to eastern architecture (which again may bear some responsibility for the "muddled" reception of the Northern Cemetery crematorium at the time of its inauguration). Kühnel contributed to the organisation of the 1909 National Exhibition, and he may have drawn inspiration from this influential experience in his crematorium. The reference to the Mausoleum in his own work certainly allowed him to engage in a relatively brief but quite intense moment of Danish "Mausoleumania" that earlier had inspired some of his most celebrated peers, Kampmann and Rosen, while appropriating the form for an entirely different function.

The second motivation springs from the fact that both practical and symbolic aspects of the Mausoleum probably appealed to Kühnel who was, as we saw, confronted with the challenge of designing a whole new kind of building with few architectural antecedents, especially in Denmark. Modelling a crematorium on the most famous funerary monument from classical antiquity certainly makes sense. In spite of being situated inside the city walls of ancient Halicarnassus, the Mausoleum was part of a sacred-funeral complex with a practical affinity with the Northern Cemetery. Pliny even described the roof of the Mausoleum as resembling a funerary pyre (*NH* 36.31: *superficies pyrae modo*). Both the form and the name of the mausoleum itself has ever since antiquity been associated with death and aspirations for the afterlife (something that is also reflected in Ølsgaard's relief decoration). There was additionally an element of pragmatism to the choice of the stepped pyramid roof in that it allowed Kühnel to integrate and essentially hide the chimney within an elegant architectural feature, similar to his earlier solution for storing water hoses in the Ny Munkegade fire station (in addition to Jacobsen's solution at Bispebjerg).

A third reason for Kühnel's choice of model takes us back to his days as a student and how this could have firmly placed the Mausoleum within his architectural imaginary. In 1870, the same year that Kühnel entered the Royal Danish Academy, the art historian Julius Lange (1838-96) had just arrived as a new professor.[65] Lange was one of the first Danish historians of classical art to see the Mausoleum sculptures that Newton had brought to the British

[64] Søberg (2023: 145).
[65] Only one year later, Lange moved on to a post at the University of Copenhagen.

Museum in 1857.[66] In a letter to Johannes Ludovicus Ussing (1820-1905), Lange discusses how during his 1867 visit he sought to "define the character of the different architectural sculptures from Greece – the Athenian, the Phigalian, the Halikarnassian, etc. – in mind and eyes, so that I will not forget them."[67] While the Mausoleum was taught in all respectable contemporary schools of architecture of the 19th century, Lange took first-hand knowledge of the monument home with him. Just three years after his return to Denmark, Lange taught Kühnel at the Royal Danish Academy, and it is likely that the young student here acquired close knowledge of the Mausoleum, both its architecture and sculptural decoration that he would later put to use in his crematorium designs. The Northern Cemetery crematorium in Aarhus was to be of one Kühnel's last works. When designing it, he had turned 67 and had had a long successful career. His decision to emulate the design of the Mausoleum may have been a nostalgic nod back to Lange's lectures in his student years.

Regardless of Kühnel's intentions, his crematorium ultimately failed its purpose. Little more than only twenty years after its completion, it was demolished in 1946 and has since been largely forgotten (Fig. 13). Ultimately, several practical and ritual deficiencies converged to bring about its demise. Already in its first year of operation, newspapers reported that it had not lived up to the ambitions of its builders, as only 29 out of a roughly 1000 annual burials in the city had been cremations.[68] Additionally, the lack of a condolence hall or other facilities for mourning rituals were criticised early on by the architect Christian Svane who characterised the crematorium as "a definite mistake never to be repeated".[69] Svane also objected to the building's exterior. In 1933, the chair of the Danish Cremation Society then published a seething critique of the crematorium, arguing that it had been "erroneously constructed from A to Z…by an architect who has entirely failed to understand the required technical details".[70] The choice of coke as a fuel was another contributing factor to the downfall of the Kühnel's crematorium, as gas had quickly become more common. The final cremation was undertaken in 1941, after which a new gas-fired cremator was installed underneath the chapel at the other end of the central axis of the cemetery. Finally, in 1946 the

[66] Funder, Kristensen and Nørskov (2019: 83-84).
[67] Lange (1902: 16-18).
[68] *Fyens Stiftstidende,* 9 January 1924, p. 1 ("Aarhus-Krematoriet er blevet en Skuffelse").
[69] Svane (1928: 36-7, quote from 37: "et absolut Fejlgreb, der aldrig bør gentages"). Based on these experiences, later crematoria were typically constructed in a basement below the chapel, as indeed happened in Aarhus Northern Cemetery after Kühnel's crematorium was demolished. In 1940, Svane was responsible for constructing a crematorium in the basement of the Northern Cemetery chapel (Aarhus Municipality, Byggesagsarkiv, Sagsnr. 160-1940).
[70] *Aarhuus Stifts-Tidende*, 29 November 1933, p. 3 ("Ligbrændingssagens Stilling i Aarhus").

board of the cemetery opted for the demolition of the old crematorium.[71] Ironically, it was during the demolition work that many of our extant images of the crematorium were taken.

Conclusion

Kühnel's crematorium in Aarhus's Northern Cemetery represents some level of engagement with the wider movement of interwar architects that sought to re-invent classical models within a vernacular framework. As discussed, his near-contemporary colleague Kampmann made a similar pivot towards the classical in his later works that developed into a considerably more restrained, "stripped down" classicism, most famously represented by his late masterpiece, the Copenhagen Police Headquarters (1918-24).[72] Kühnel's turn towards the Mausoleum represents something much less radical and inventive. Yet it still demonstrates how a Danish architect during the interwar period was able to incorporate a prominent reference to classical architecture within an eclectic framework that reflected the civic ambitions of Denmark's second city and its place within the world system of classicism, as well as constituting an elegant solution to the practical problem of constructing a crematorium. In this way he translated a highly characteristic element of one specific classical model into a vernacular building, constructed from red brick and with more traditional historicist references to medieval castle architecture. The Northern Cemetery crematorium in this sense constitutes an expression of a tradition of vernacular classicism that sought to incorporate classical designs into a firmly local architectural idiom.

The case of the Northern Cemetery furthermore demonstrates some of the complexities and multiple layers to the trajectory of classicising architecture over the course of the 20th century that has followed several different paths. Many such cases are found in smaller cities and towns where the chain of transmission from the classical to the vernacular and the many layers of translation that go with this process can be difficult to identify in detail. These layers were deeply tied to the individual choices of artists and architects who were not satisfied with simply bringing "the light from the Athenian Acropolis" to northern Europe but instead sought to adapt distinctive elements from classical architecture and art into vernacular

[71] *Demokraten* 23 March 1946, p. 1 ("Det gamle Krematorium paa Nordre Kirkegaard skal nedrives"); *Aarhuus Stifts-Tidende* 5 July 1946 ("Krematoriet rives ned"). Plans to replace the crematorium with an urn wall also never materialised, and the space is now used for the display of funeral wreaths.
[72] Stewart (2018: 77-92). Asplund's Stockholm Public Library (1920-28) is another example of this "Nordic Classicism".

forms of expression.[73] The dominant architectural language in Kühnel's Denmark was that of historicism and firmly based on an ideology of National Romanticism that in the Danish case responded to the considerable national trauma of losing considerable swathes of land in the war of 1864. However, within this paradigm of historicism and national pride, variant forms of vernacular classicism still thrived, drawing on sometimes quite isolated references to classical architecture, such as the Mausoleum of Halicarnassus that as one of the wonders of the ancient world always constituted a model for emulation and appropriation in any architect's imaginary. Similar to several Danish colleagues around the turn of the century, in his design of the Northern Cemetery crematorium, Kühnel participated in this creative process of architectural re-invention of the Mausoleum and provided an example of a particular kind of vernacular classicism adapted to the context of a cemetery in Denmark's "second city" as well as his own personal biography.

Captions

Fig. 1. S.F. Kühnel's crematorium in the Northern Cemetery of Aarhus, depicted in 1924 or 1925, photo: Emil Andersen Ebbesen (courtesy of the Photo Archive of Den Gamle By).

Fig. 2. Hack Kampmann's Aarhus Theatre (1900), photographed by Edvard Monsrud between 1908 and 1912 (courtesy of Aarhus Stadsarkiv).

Fig. 3. Overview of the 1909 National Exhibition in Aarhus, with the Carlsberg triumphal column (upper left), main exhibition hall in the style of a Doric temple (lower left), and the Tuborg triumphal arch (centre), photo: Joseph Allin (courtesy of the Photo Archive of Den Gamle By).

Fig. 4. Poster from the 1909 National Exhibition, with city seal above the central horseshoe frame depicting the pediment of the Hall of Industry and a provisional design for the Tower of Electricity. The old cathedral and the city's harbour are seen in the background (WikiMedia Commons).

Fig. 5. Aarhus Central Train Station (1926), designed by Knud Tanggård Seest (1879-1972), seen in 1929 or 1930, photo: Emil Andersen Ebbesen (courtesy of the Photo Archive of Den Gamle By).

Fig. 6. Original architectural drawing by Sophus Kühnel of his design for the Northern Cemetery, looking north-south, dated 1918 (courtesy of the Aarhus Stadsarkiv).

Fig. 7. Kühnel's 1918 plan of the Northern Cemetery, showing the location of chapel

[73] On "the light from the Acropolis" as the guiding principle of early 19th-century Danish classicism, see Christiansen (2000).

("Kapel") and crematorium ("Krematorium") (courtesy of the Aarhus Stadsarkiv).
Fig. 8. Holger Jacobsen's Bispebjerg crematorium (1906-7), shown here in 1913 (courtesy of Museum of Copenhagen).
Fig. 9. Kühnel's 1918 draft for the interior plan of the crematorium in the Northern Cemetery, showing location of oven ("Ovn"), catafalque on the left and furnace room ("Fyrrum") to the right (courtesy of Aarhus Stadsarkiv).
Fig. 10. Reconstruction model of the Mausoleum of Halikarnassos by Kristian Jeppesen, Museum of Ancient Art and Archaeology, Aarhus University (photo: author).
Fig. 11. Francesco Colonna's "Sun Temple" in the *Hypnerotomachia Poliphilii*, 1499 (courtesy of the Metropolitan Museum of Art).
Fig. 12. The Ny Carlsberg Glyptotek pyramid by Hack Kampmann (courtesy of Ny Carlsberg Glyptotek / Anders Sune Berg).
Fig. 13. Demolition of the Northern Cemetery crematorium in 1946. Two workers have ascended to the top of the "pyramid" (courtesy of the Aarhus City Archives and Aarhus Stiftstidende).

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